



A lesson in failure: England's top order failed to make a telling impact, leaving Joe Root and Harry Brook, along with Jacob Bethell (right) — one of its standout players — to shoulder most of the burden. GETTY IMAGES & AP

production where it mattered most. Head's dominance set the tone, but the depth beneath him was telling. Steve Smith averaged 57.2. Carey, batting lower, outscored most of England's top order. Australia did not rely on one pillar. England, without solidity at No. 3, was repeatedly exposed early.

In the end, this Ashes did not turn on moments of drama or fortune, but on fundamentals exposed over time. Australia stripped the contest back to its essentials and found it still held the advantage. England arrived with belief, but belief proved insufficient when not reinforced by preparation, durability and clarity of role.

Stats inputs by Sahil Mathur

